

bringing lunch to work every day and the other always paying for lunch at a restaurant. Rockman, who's been with her partner for thirteen years, said sometimes you don't think a small money habit will bother you until it eats at you over time.

Another consideration as a couple is the degree to which you will be splitting expenses. Will expenses be split evenly, or prorated according to how much each person earns? Will they be pooled into one pot of money everyone can use? I'd argue for prorating by earnings as long as the person making more money doesn't resent the person making less. This way, no one's income is being unfairly drained, that is, neither partner has to "live up" or "live down" to what the other can afford.

Kristin F. Jones, a licensed marriage and family therapist in Los Angeles, advises couples to consider that money isn't the only currency in a relationship. A comedian couple I know told me that in the beginning of their relationship, when one of them made more money, the other took care of all household chores, including laundry and cleaning. This arrangement greatly reduced their stress and allowed both to contribute significantly to the relationship. The larger earner said she appreciated her partner doing the stuff she wasn't around to do, and it meant more to her than splitting expenses evenly.

Contributions are not just financial, so think about more than just money when combining finances and choosing how to split expenses. Other forms of labor count too.



TAKEAWAYS

- ° Dating is hard, especially when it comes to spending money on a partner. Try not to make assumptions about someone's situation based on background or gender, and don't put on a money front you can't maintain.